benevolence of the victor. The winner does not rub the loser's face in the mud. But the outcome of the struggle must be clear to both sides. A battle whose result is ambiguous is an invitation for trouble. The Ottomans provided many examples of this behavior: they crushed the rebels with a strong hand but did not humiliate them. They showed generosity toward them and even helped them to rehabilitate themselves. If the powerful party does not exhaust its ability to achieve such a victory, its behavior is interpreted as cowardice.

Is it an exaggeration to call this a clash of civilizations? According to Lewis, these differences are of great significance. The Christian world and the Muslim world have been at odds and fought against each other on many fronts for more than a thousand years. In the late eighteenth century, there were dozens of Oriental studies departments in Western universities, and hundreds of translations of Arabic, Persian, and Turkish works were printed. The Western world longed to understand its historical adversary. But this curiosity did not go both ways. In the Muslim world, scholars did not learn the languages of the West, were not interested in Western history and thought, and did not often translate Western literature into Arabic. Things changed a little once they realized the force of the Western threat, but curiosity about the "other" is a distinctly Western phenomenon. In Muslim society, this interest arises only in the face of a threat. This cultural phenomenon may not last forever, but it is more deeply rooted than many people tend to think.

What will the long-term effects of the war in Afghanistan be? People like bin Laden and some Palestinians thought that the West and Israel had "gone soft" and wouldn't have the stomach to wage a war. The Afghanistan war, as well as Israel's response to the al-Aqsa Intifada, proved that the West is determined to fight when its civilization is attacked. Now there are two possibilities: either the people of Muslim world, especially the Arabs, decide that in order to establish a better society they must choose the path of peace and cooperation with the West, or they choose to believe that their defeat was simply an unfortunate episode and that they must continue along their current path. For now, they seem to have chosen the latter option of continued struggle, and their means is international terrorism. When I say *they,* I do not mean all Arabs or all Muslims. The use of the word *they* is qualitative, not quantitative or statistical. "They" in this case are those who determine the agenda and implement their apocalyptic vision.